The Brand Axis: Strategic Impacts of Loyalty and Engagement within the Social Media Magnet Theory

ABSTRACT

The Social Media Magnet is presented as a new pedagogy for organic, inbound marketing instruction. This methodology has now been deployed for the last six years across multiple universities combining a digital online delivery system with a new theory and a live online practicum to teach college students both strategic and tactical planning for digital marketing campaigns. Using live website creation, social media planning tools, and email retention campaigns, students using this pedagogy learn the best practices for inbound marketing. This is not a simulation, but a live practicum that teaches students real-time inbound marketing principles. This paper recaps the Social Media Magnet Theory and Practicum but develops a deeper theoretical understanding of The Brand Axis, a strategic tool that will be used to measure brand loyalty and engagement, providing a strategic prescription for how brands can keep their brand messaging centered on the four brand elements: Story, Promise, Belief, and Trust.

INTRODUCTION

Social media has changed the marketing environment in ways that traditional marketers could have never imagined just a decade ago. It has rapidly provided a mechanism to communicate on a one-to-one level, allowing marketers to tailor specific messages and content towards a fine-tuned segment of customers, whether they are business-to- consumer (B2C), business-to-business (B2B), or even business-to-government (B2G). Multiple philosophies on best practices in this digital landscape have provided various methodologies for targeting these customers. During this time of change, these practices have led to the refinement of digital services, including behavioral advertising, search engine optimization, pay per click, content marketing, social media marketing, and organic inbound marketing, among specialized others. In fact, digital agencies today are for the most part narrowly niched providing only few services to a couple of distinct target segments. Hence, when a professor considers the opportunity to teach in the digital arena, the coverage of topics and the timeliness of content seem extremely daunting. The question that lay before academics is, how do we teach these tactics in a way that stays both timely and applicable?

The answer to this question is tactically impossible, but strategically manageable. In other words, the focus of any pedagogy in this arena is to not teach all the tactical operations of digital marketing, but teach sustainable strategies. Teaching only tactics would be impossible due to the rapidly changing nature of the digital marketing toolset. Google and Facebook change their algorithms considerably often, seemingly almost daily. Additionally, new platforms like Snapchat spring up quickly due to innovative platform design. If academics tried to teach these tactics in a textbook format, then by the time the textbook would be printed, the content would be out of date. This truth is also what keeps most academics from wanting to teach a digital marketing class.

However, the pedagogy presented in this article is different. It stresses the strategic principles of marketing, and more directly, pull marketing. The intent is to use the foundation knowledge from the last seventy-five years to build upon marketing principles that will teach students how to approach digital marketing strategically, teaching them a new theoretical model, known here at The Social Media Magnet. With this theory as their conceptual orientating framework, sound digital marketing strategies can be taught and learned. Of course, there will be some tactical discussion alongside the implementation of the theory; however, we present teaching the tactics around a live practicum that we believe is essential to the learning process of this paradigm. This live practicum will allow students to dive into the tactical application of the marketing principles they are learning in the class at the strategic level. It is here at this practical level that students will achieve the hands-on experience of the current tactics, which will change from semester-to-semester, allowing them to build their tactical toolkits, while simultaneously allowing them to build their critical thinking skills around the strategic principles that have and will continue to govern the process of marketing.

Finally, since students are most often on a restrictive personal budget and because current statistics indicate the increasing usefulness of pull marketing campaigns, The Social Media Magnet is taught completely from an inbound, organic perspective. In fact, seventy-four percent of businesses surveyed in the most recent 2018 State of Inbound Report (HubSpot) claim to be using these approaches today. The economic return and ability to analytically track the invested return on these organic campaigns, as well as the demonetarized value of these learning opportunities for college students, makes this the optimal segment to teach inbound principles as a knowledge foundation.

Lastly, we argue that not only is this true for college students, but also any company or business campaign. This orientation is in no way critical of digital agencies or their ability to assist

companies in their paid digital marketing efforts, but our contention is that if companies had the resources to deploy these strategic principles internally, then digital agencies assistance with paid digital marketing efforts would be unwarranted. However, as is the case with many small and growing firms, an emphasis has been put more on the immediacy of assistance through agency help, rather than building a digital department from within the company. And while agencies will continue to assist many companies in the future, our hope is that by training college students around these pedagogies, they will be equipped to immediately step in and help companies increase their own brand awareness and ROI by focusing both message and goals through an organic approach. Likewise, these skills will also create a stronger knowledge foundation to be shared with future agencies when the company is possibly ready to expand its budgets into the paid arena. Therefore, the goal of The Social Media Magnet is to educate a market of college students capable of directing and managing the overall brand, from brand story to social media deployment to analytical audit through a both a digital delivery system and live online practicum.

THE SOCIAL MEDIA MAGNET THEORY

With little doubt, the Internet has become the foundation for knowledge dissemination today, and smartphones have changed the immediacy of this dissemination forever. In the palm of our hands, we have infinite knowledge through a mere Google search, and the choice of immediate connection to society should we desire it. Since the advent of Web 2.0, our society has moved from services offering channels of networked communication to becoming an interactive, two-way vehicle for networked sociality (Castells 2007). No longer does information just flow in one direction from companies or governments down to the rest of society, but now each member of society can participate in the creation and dissemination of this knowledge. This is what has become known as the horizontal revolution (Tuten and Solomon 2015). The fundamental tool of this revolution has become social media. The most common definition for social media includes tools that allow people to create and share user-generated content in the form of information, interests, ideas, pictures, videos, etc. in virtual communities and networks (Kaplan and Haenlein 2010).

The priority of social media in consumer acquisition is to become a content leader. Over the last few years, Hubspot has taught us about the importance of inbound marketing. The historical nature of outbound marketing has led most businesses to spend a majority of their time pushing out messages into the marketplace and hope that it resonates with people, leading them back to their service. However, inbound marketing is the process of establishing a website like a “hub” that attracts visitors naturally to a company’s content through search engines, blogging, and

social media (Hubspot). This inbound approach converts an audience of strangers through an online goal funnel by attracting them through functional content on a blog or social media channel. This content is relevant to the questions and timing at hand, and through the company's command and leadership on the topic, converts strangers into visitors. Then, the visitors begin to return on a regular basis, looking for new strategies, ideas, and forms. This is when the site begins to call them to action through various landing pages that discuss the company's expertise and provided services. These inquiring visitors then turn to leads, where they are entered into a CRM (customer relationship management) database that provides regular emails and workflow strategies. Next, leads turn into customers, whereby the company can provide smart content, specialized services, post-purchase surveys, and engage in social monitoring, whereby turning customers into promoting advocates. But throughout this process, inbound methodology begins and ends with content. By publishing the timely content in an accessible location, the company's marketing message becomes relevant and helpful to their customers, not disruptive.

Alongside the content, companies must also utilize social media and search engine optimization techniques for helping customers find the accessible location, i.e. a company's website. Being listed at the top of search engine results drives traffic to the company's website. Additionally, social media sites are created to tell success stories, highlight current projects, drive brand recognition, spark engagement, and most importantly, drive traffic back to the source of the content leadership as well. With SEO and social media driving traffic back to the hub of content leadership, a company's inbound marketing strategy will begin to produce organic results; that is, in this scenario, the results are leads that they didn't have to pay for from any third-party advertiser. Using this historical knowledge of inbound marketing as a baseline, The Social Media Magnet has been created as a process of using a company's message and medium to create inertia for attracting a target audience that gravitates toward content that will direct them into goal conversion funnel whereby turning views to visitors to leads to consumers, while providing new pedagogical tools like the Message Matrix, a 90-day Rolling Editorial Calendar, and a live digital practicum to educate students on the strategic planning and implementation of an inbound marketing approach. The Social Magnet is the impetus for engagement leading to goal conversions, the direct result of a successful digital inbound marketing campaign.

At a holistic level, the Social Magnet is a conceptual model that will guide strategic discussions throughout the course of an educational semester. At a strategic level, it is the process of planning a company's message through selected media to create inertia within a defined segment. At a tactical level, it is the implementation of these plans through individual

communication channels targeted towards a selected audience that directs them into a conversion funnel whereby turning views to visitors to leads to consumers to advocates.

Three Primary Components: The Brand Hub, Infinity Loop, and Message Magnet

The Brand Hub

The Social Magnet is a new inbound model that theorizes how companies create a successful inbound marketing campaign. It is modeled as hub-and-spoke design. Each spok***e*** is a single digital channel with multiple messages pushed out by the company or individual with the goal of attracting the audience closer to the brand in hopes to move that consumer through some type of engagement and ultimately, a goal conversion process at the company's brand hub, represented online as their website or blog. The construction of this new theoretical model is made up of three parts: the brand hub, the message magnet, and the infinity loop. The brand hub (Figure 1) is the centered balancing force of the model. Whenever the magnet becomes out of balance, it is the four key brand elements that will re-center the company and its message. Just below, we will discuss the essential brand elements that must come first in planning any inbound marketing campaign.

Figure 1. The Brand Hub and the Four Brand Elements



Before starting any inbound marketing campaign, or when trying to re-center from a magnetic misalignment, the company or individual should spend a considerable amount of time developing a brand and what we believe are its four key elements: Brand Story, Brand Promise, Brand Beliefs, and Brand Trust. The brand name needs to be something that will be relevant to the target audience and something that will continue to inspire years after the website, product, or blog launch. The design might include something that inspires from a book or movie. It could

be a play on words or humorous, or maybe a title that uses alliteration. After the brand is chosen, more content development is needed around the four brand elements in order be able to consistently keep the magnet's messages consistent and on brand. As stated previously, the brand hub is the center most balancing force of any organic inbound campaign. If the message becomes off-brand, then the magnet will begin to fail and results will suffer.

The Brand Story

For The Social Media Magnet theory, the brand elements are the most important component of the inbound campaign because they are the strategic foundation for every marketing decision. Much like a mission statement, every other decision builds upon these core branding decisions. In any future decision, if the outcome is in opposition to the brand elements, then one should decide against it. For example, take the online sensation Doug the Pug.

When speaking to a group, Leslie Mosier, who owns Doug, claims everything she does must be on-brand and within the brand story. "To keep Doug on brand, I ask myself if I like the product. If I don't like it, neither does Doug." In fact, Leslie has turned down advertising placements for Doug because she does not personally like the taste of the product. This authenticity allows Leslie to consistently stay on-brand. Therefore, everything Doug sponsors must be on-brand and represents Doug as the "King of Pop Culture." Note, a brand story can be either personal or metaphoric. A personal story is how the individual or the company came to be involved in the current enterprise. It could be a story about the personal journey into this topical domain, or how the company came up with the idea, product, or service. If the story is metaphoric, then while it may not be an actual story, it is a realistic narrative around the concept or idea. Within the creation of the story, questions the story will answer revolve around emotion, authenticity, and its possibly historical viability.

Brand Promise

Once the brand story has been created, the next step is to consider the promises that the individual or company will make to its consumers. The goal here is to create three to four promises that the individual or company will always uphold. If the brand story is a mission statement, then the brand promise is the vision statement. What are those things that a company will promise to do for their customers and how do they intend to keep this promise? This can be carried out in the form of a money-back guarantee, a customer service pledge, an assurance of content leadership, or many other types of promises. For example, the visionary promise by Bass

Pro Shops that was cast upon their merger with Cabela's stated:

"As we move forward, we are committed to retaining everything customers love about both Bass Pro Shops and Cabela's by creating a 'best-of-the-best' experience that includes the superior products, outstanding customer service and exceptional value our customers have come to expect. We're also deeply motivated by the potential to significantly advance key conservation initiatives."

Bass Pro promised here to stock superior products, maintain outstanding customer service, and provide exceptional value for its customers, while advancing key conservation initiatives, knowing full well that if the outdoors does not continue to provide the sporting opportunities for which they sell products, then they will be out of business.

Brand Beliefs

In addition to the brand promises, brand beliefs are also important to establish as part of the core brand elements. These beliefs usually include four to five pillars of value that a company not only believes about the brand, but what they also want their consumers to believe about the brand. These values are often listed under a vision statement, or in this case, under the brand promise. For instance, an institution of higher education might list five values as essential to their community, such as Integrity, Inquiry, Collaboration, Service, and Humility. The university might then work tirelessly to make sure that not only their current students and parents believe that the university upholds these beliefs, but others in the greater community around the university, especially prospective students. For a large phone service provider like Verizon, they value integrity, respect, performance excellence, and accountability. Again, these values should build upon the brand story and support the brand promises. In this case, if Verizon demonstrates these values, then they should be able to uphold the promises that they have made to their consumers.

Brand Trust

Finally, trust is a hard measure to earn. It may take years of consistent promise keeping and belief building before a consumer may finally trust a company and their message. Immediately, the previous examples may cause one to pause and ask the question, do I trust these messages? Is Doug the Pug the King of Pop Culture? Does Bass Pro provide exceptional value? Can a university serve its community with humility? Is Verizon accountable? The answers to these questions relates to a consumer's level of trust in the company. This trust is built upon the

premise of expectancy confirmation or disconfirmation. Inasmuch, Expectancy Disconfirmation Theory (Oliver 1977) compares an individual's expectations with their actual perceived performance. If the levels of actuals are consistent with the expectations, then satisfaction has occurred. However, if the expectations are significantly greater, or significantly less, in magnitude and/or importance than the actual performance, then dissatisfaction can occur. This dissatisfaction leads to a decrease in trust.

Likewise, inbound marketing strategies must also build trust. Most notably, this comes in the form of an action plan to deal with consumer responses. As consumers engage with editorial content, especially in the form of comments, a company must decide how to respond to both affirming and disaffirming comments. For this reason, many companies have set up listening centers to monitor what is occurring online. For example, Southwest Airlines has a dedicated space in their Fort Worth headquarters designed specifically to respond to online consumer's complaints (and praises) in just a matter of minutes.

Therefore, the last brand element questions facing each company is, do I trust my audience's responses and will they trust me? As these questions suggest, trust is a two-way street. It is a personal relationship that is built over time as satisfaction by both parties is accomplished and repeated. When this trust is broken, as with any relationship, it is imperative for the company to assess where the trust has been diluted and establish a mechanism to repair the damage. Finding methods to assess these relationships are critical, whether that is setting up a listening center, monitoring active channels in real time through tools like Hootsuite, or having periodic checks of social media channels and disqus online. Creating a monitoring process is critical to all inbound campaigns.

The Message Magnet

The next component is the message magnet (Figure 2). Extending out from the brand hub, will be a company's marketing messages. These messages extend out from the hub into the targeted audience through communication vehicles, like a company website, social media, and email. As these messages are delivered, they will either attract consumers toward the brand or repel them away. Additionally, as a company reaches more consumers with its message, the size of this target audience, or message magnet, can grow. Likewise, it can also shrink due to consumers moving away from the brand.

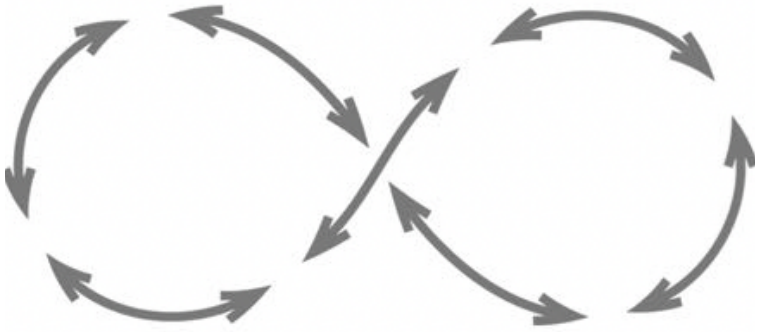
Figure 2. The Message Magnet with Channel Spokes



The Infinity Loop

The last component of the model is the infinity loop (Figure 3) which represents all customers in any market segment. While consumers are positioned somewhere on this loop, they can flow in either direction, towards the brand or away from the brand located correctly in the center of the loop. For this reason, the infinity loop stretches both inside and outside the message magnet's borders, as seen in Figure 4. Additionally, the infinity loop can grow or shrink depending on the total size of the market segment; however, it does not grow or shrink at a rapid pace due to the larger cultural forces at play that make it more difficult to grow or shrink a segment's total market size.

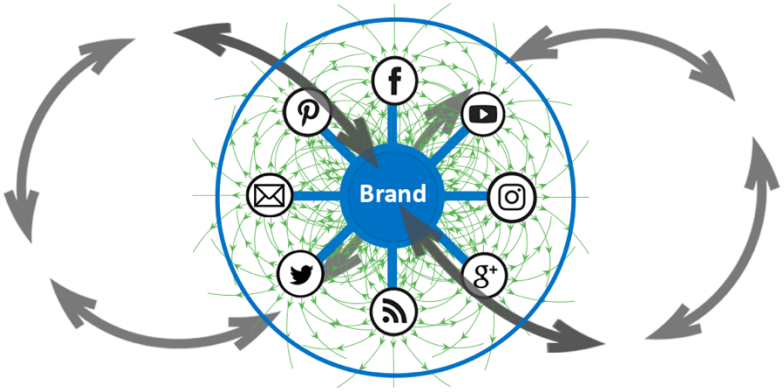
Figure 3. The Infinity Loop



When we combine all of these components, we complete The Social Media Magnet model. Envision the message magnet like an impulse engine. It pulses out messages (highlighted below

as green arrows) along the spokes from the various communication channels, and if consumers find these messages within the various channels, then their response to the message will end up pushing them or pulling them along the infinity loop either towards or away from the brand hub. The consumer will move closer to the brand hub if he or she interprets the message as positive, or further away from the brand hub if the interpretation of the message is negative. This process of attracting and repelling consumers speaks to the heart of the social media magnet and the marketing message mix. The message will either keep consumers within range of continually hearing the marketing message, inside of the message magnet's border, or they will move beyond the message outside of the message magnet's border. The message magnet's borders represent the target audience to the extent that those individuals who are closer to the brand hub are more loyal and engaged consumers while those closer to the edge of the border are only seldom or first- time users of the product, service, or content. Consumers outside of the border are not users at all, representing potential consumers who are either unaware or have forgotten about the company's message due to environmental or competitive forces.

Figure 4. The Social Media Magnet in Action

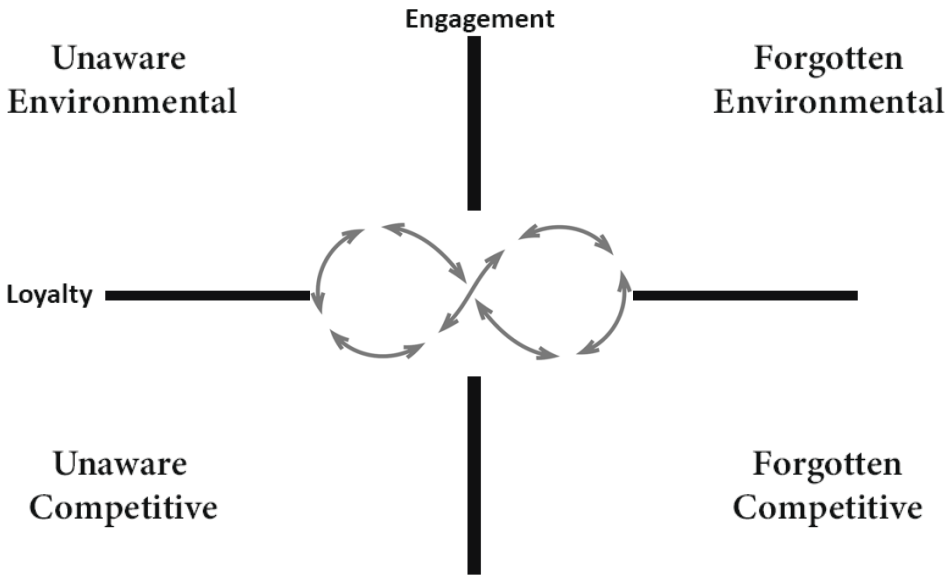


THE BRAND AXIS

As we discussed above, the infinity loop represents the never-ending process of attracting, and potentially repelling customers due to an individual's or company's marketing message, i.e. the inertia of the message magnet. As history has demonstrated, some marketing messages are well received and create highly charged magnetic responses. Like a real magnet, this polarized charge would draw in additional consumers of the target audience along the infinity loop. However, the infinity loop is not uni-directional, meaning is does not flow unitarily in the same direction always. The Social Media Magnet attracts from all paths along the infinity loop, as the consumers can be attracted into the message magnet from any direction. Likewise, a message

that would repel consumers due to the decreased inertia of a poorly targeted message can also push consumers away in any direction along the infinity loop. Therefore, the infinity loop provides the opportunity to orient multiple dimensions of impact upon the target market. Specifically, The Social Media Magnet theorizes both vertical and horizontal impacts upon the brand. This theoretical mapping of these axes is called the Brand Axis. The Brand Axis measures the loyalty and engagement of a target audience as it relates to their own awareness of the brand in the landscape surrounding that brand.

Figure 5. The Brand Axis



Within the Brand Axis, the model theorizes the dimensional impact of "Loyalty" as represented by message awareness on the X-axis. Consumers on the far left of the axis are considered to have no loyalty due to being completely unaware of the message. In contrast, the consumers on the far right of the axis have no loyalty because they have completely forgotten the message. Note, both ends of the axis are not an ideal orientation to an individual or company relative to their marketing message. The ideal archetype for the loyalty dimension is directly in the center of the matrix, where the extensions of the infinity loop cross in the middle. However, in the middle ground between both end points and the center of the axis, there are varying levels to the degree of awareness demarcating levels of skepticism about the consumers' awareness or forgetfulness of the brand. Consumers who would say, "Yeah, I think I have heard of that brand" or "Yeah, I

think I remember that brand" would qualify for this middle ground, representing a continuum of awareness on this X-axis.

Along the vertical Y-axis, the model theorizes the dimensional impact of "Engagement" as this consumer engagement is prevented due to extraneous forces on the brand message. At the top of the Y-axis, consumers are distracted from the marketing message due to environmental forces. At the bottom of the Y-axis, consumers are distracted from the marketing message due to competitive forces. Again, both the top and the bottom of the axis are not an ideal orientation on the plot, as the ideal is again directly in the center of the matrix, where the extensions of the infinity loop cross in the middle. Although, again, in the middle ground between both end points and the center of the axis, there are varying levels to the degree of impact of these forces on the consumers level of engagement with the brand. Consumers who would say, "Yeah, I can't afford that brand anymore" or "Yeah, I like this other brand better" would qualify for this middle ground, representing a continuum of engagement on this Y-axis.

The ideal scenario is that the message magnet is centered right in the middle of the infinity loop where the loop is directly aligned at center with the engagement and loyalty axes. At this stage, the marketing message is completely on-brand and consumers on the infinity loop within the boundaries of the message magnet are the ideal target audience. However, The Social Media Magnet Theory suggests that events can occur that cause a message magnet to become misaligned, or in other words, the message magnet can drift off the center of the loyalty and engagement axes. This event, called magnetic misalignment, would indicate that the marketing message is not being denoted correctly by the target audience and the company's marketing message is becoming off-target. As indicated from Figure 5, this could occur in one of four scenarios, depending on the drift into one of the four quadrants on the Brand Axis.

The Strategic Impact of the Brand Axis

The Brand Axis is divided into four quadrants as partitioned by the Loyalty and Engagement axes. Recall that left of the Engagement axis are consumers who register as unaware on the loyalty scale. For these consumers that are unaware, the Brand Axis indicates those consumers are unaware either due to the environmental landscape forces or due to competitive landscape forces. In the top left quadrant, the matrix represents consumers who have not heard the company's (or individual's) marketing message due to the environmental landscape. Whether it is socio-economic, cultural, regulatory forces, etc., these consumers are unaware of the brand

messaging. However, in the bottom left quadrant, the matrix represents consumers who have not heard the company (or individual's) marketing message due to the competitive landscape. In these instances, competitors have inhibited the targeted audience from hearing the brand message. For example, it could be that the competition has a larger overall marketing budget and the sheer volume of their messages is drowning out the company's (or individual's) attempt to communicate.

However, consumers mapped to the right of the Engagement axis are those who are not loyal to the brand because they have forgotten about the brand. These are consumers who at one point were aware of the brand and their message, but over time have moved away as the brand fell from their consideration set. For these consumers that have forgotten the brand, the Brand Axis also identifies their extinction based on either environmental or competitive landscape forces. In the top right quadrant, the matrix represents consumers who have forgotten about the company's (or individual's) marketing message due to the environmental landscape. Whether it is socio-economic, cultural, regulatory forces, etc., these consumers who were once in tune with the brand have moved away from the brand messaging. However, in the bottom right quadrant, the matrix represents consumers who have forgotten about the company's (or individual's) marketing message due to the competitive landscape. In these instances, competitors have inhibited the targeted audience from remembering the brand message. For example, it could be that the competition has a more valuable offering and the consumer has forgotten about the company's (or individual's) product completely, or to some degree relative to the competitor's product offerings.

The Brand Axis acts as a map and compass for any company or individual running an inbound marketing campaign. Numerous consulting opportunities in this domain have demonstrated to the author's that it does not take long for the message magnet to become misaligned. Whether it is awareness or landscape factors contributing to this misalignment, it can happen quickly and is often hard to identify. For example, examine the following hypothetical scenario with the Brand Axis.

Magnetic Misalignments in Each Brand Axis Quadrant

What happens when an individual or company's message becomes misaligned, or in other words, off-brand? While a ***magnetic misalignment*** causes the message magnet to move away from being centered on the Brand Axis, this conceptually implies the individual's or company's message no longer supports the brand hub strategy or the four brand elements. Many times,

especially in small to medium-sized businesses, owners seemingly chase an opportunity that will create new marketing messages that are incongruent with the main message of the firm. In these instance, these owners need to return to the primary message. They need to remember to "Keep the main thing the main thing." For example, a physical therapy clinic shouldn't run messaging that they perform hearing tests. Even though physical therapy clinics may often assist people with vertigo due to inner-ear problems, the balance disorder is the main thing. Yes, there is a connection between hearing and inner-ear issues, and while the clinicians may holistically want to help these patients with inner-ear disorders, the clinic needs to remember that it does not special in audiology, but in physical therapy. It is these authors' experience through consulting that this is a frequent occurrence in the marketplace. Furthermore, when the messaging becomes off-brand, then current content that does help maintain the business's normal operating efficiencies will start to be disrupted.

It is imperative here to stress the critical importance of keeping The Social Media Magnet adequately balanced. This requires messages to remain centered on the four brand elements discussed in Chapter 2. Successful inbound marketing campaigns reinforce the brand story, promise, and beliefs, while maintaining and building levels of trust with consumers. If the message wonders off brand, then unforeseen consequences mentioned above can occur, like focusing on the wrong target market, or presenting marketing messages that do not resonate with the target audience. Furthermore, these effects could be a result of poor internal managerial decisions or from outside the firm in the form of environmental or competitive forces changing consumer perceptions. In any of these situations, a managerial perspective focused on the core brand elements will bring the Social Media Magnet back into alignment and stabilize the social model.

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In the following sections, we will deeply explore each of the Brand Axis Quadrants, focusing on potential internal decisions and external factors that could either pull or push the message magnet off the center of the Brand Axis and towards a specific quadrant. Finally, we will end each section with potential remedies on how to re-align the message magnet to the center of the Brand Axis.

Quadrant A: Acquisition Focus within Environmental Uncertainty

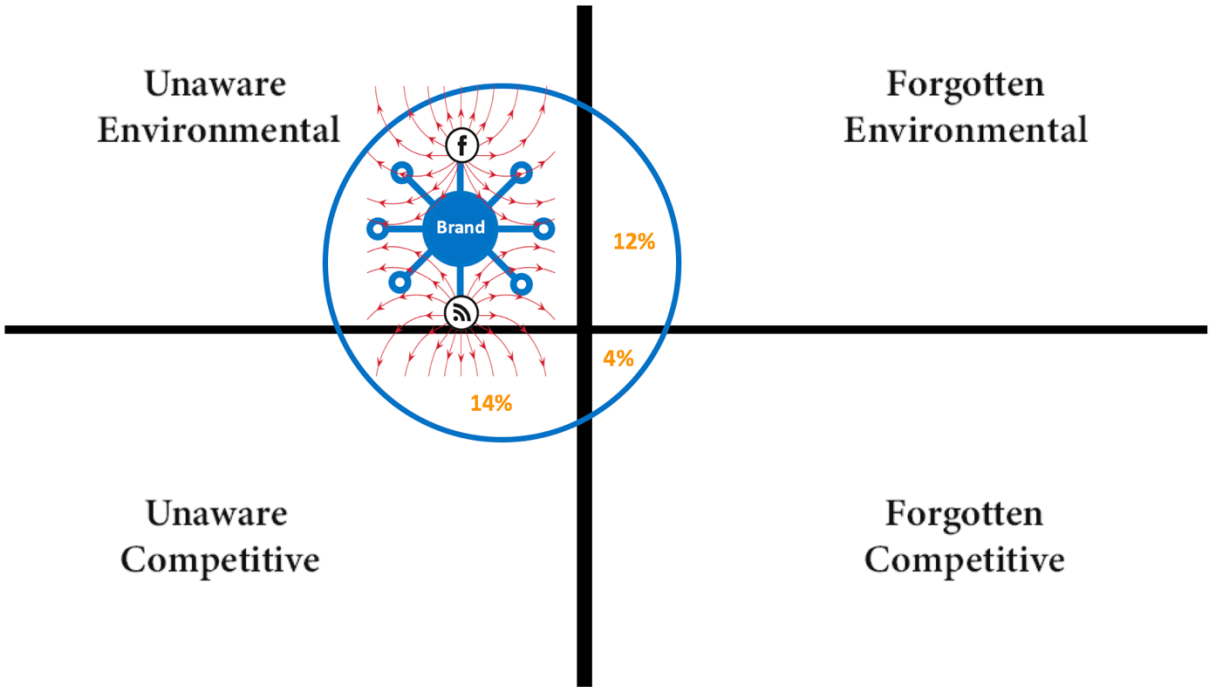
The first quadrant of the Brand Axis includes consumers who are typically unaware of the company's (or individual's) brand due to environmental distractions. As discussed in the previous chapters, consumers positioned closest to the X-axis are conceptually less distracted by uncertain environmental conditions, while those further away from the same axis are more distracted by uncertain environmental conditions. Likewise, consumers closest to the Y-axis are conceptually more aware than those further away from the same axis.

The Situation

When companies (or individuals) begin to target consumers in this quadrant, then they have become magnetically misaligned as an acquisition strategy in order to focus more heavily on ascertaining new customers that have never, or very rarely, purchased their product or service previously. However, in this particular quadrant, these consumers are not being distracted by competitive offerings, but are uncertain of the product due to environmental constraints. These environmental constraints can include socio-economic, political/regulatory, cultural, or technological forces that prohibit a consumer from purchasing. Whether the reason includes not having enough money, not having the technological ability, not having a cultural significance, or not having the access to the product or service, consumers in this quadrant do not have the knowledge that the product or service is even available to them. This lack of awareness keeps them outside of the targeted audience of the balanced message magnet centered over the direct middle of the Brand Axis.

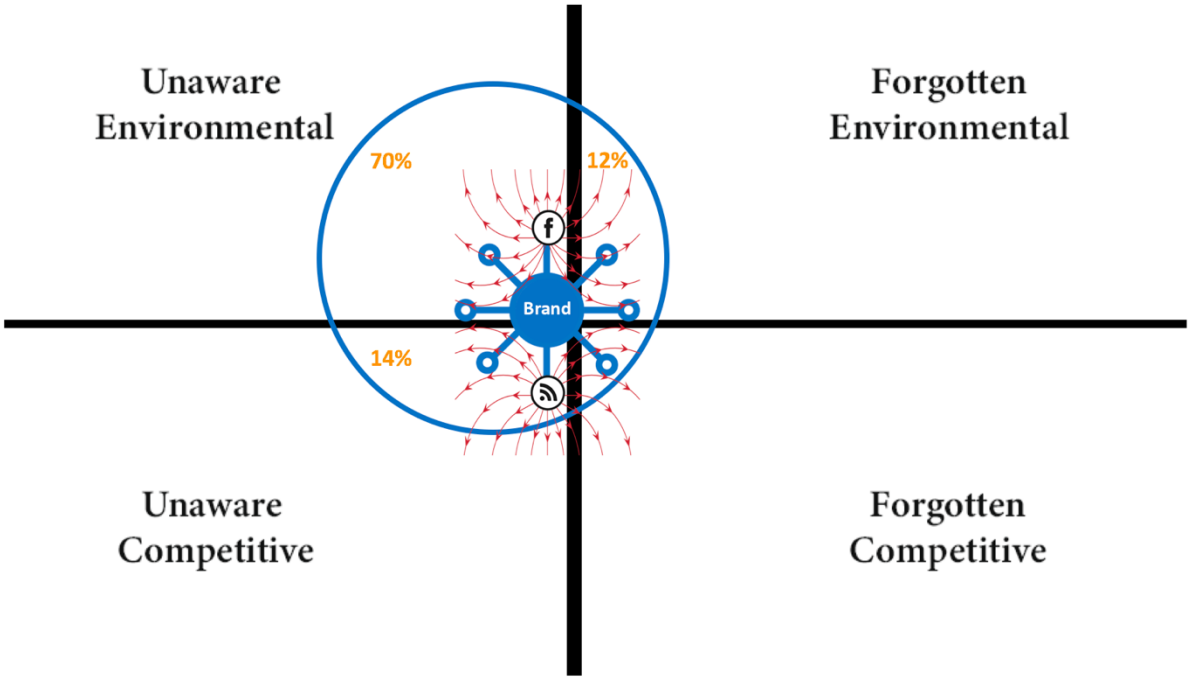
When conducting a situational analysis, companies (or individuals) may become aware and too focused on accessing these consumers at the expense of their entire branding message. This is what is known as a ***misaligned push scenario***, which is due to a company's (or individual's) own internal strategic decisions. In these "push" cases, a hyper-focus on a quadrant of consumers can cause a company to become misaligned, moving the message magnet from the center of the Brand Axis into the focused quadrant. [Note, a market share growth into this quadrant is possible with a balanced message over time, meaning that the size of the message magnet can grow and expand further into this quadrant, but a misaligned move into this quadrant often comes in haste, trying to capture these potential customers without a balanced campaign.] A rush to capture more consumers in the quadrant causes the message magnet to become off-brand, causing the current message magnet not to grow, but to move off center. As it moves into this quadrant, less of the message magnet becomes equally shared by the other three quadrants.

Figure 6. Quadrant A Push Scenario



For example, in the scenario above, internal decisions by this firm have pushed the message magnet off center. The push structure is indicated by the hub, which is typically in the center of the message magnet where the brand and the brand spokes consist, has moved closer to the edge of the message magnet border, insinuating that it is pushing the entire message magnet off-center. In this case, the other quadrants, which when balanced would all be equal to 25% of the message, have become disproportionate, decreasing to 12%, 4%, and 14% respectively across the other quadrants. This means that this misaligned push approach has increased Quadrant A from a balanced approach of 25% to an unbalanced level of 70% of the marketing message.

Figure 7. Quadrant A Pull Scenario



The previous discussion focused on the internal decisions that cause companies (or individuals) to strategically push the message magnet into misalignment. In another realistic scenario, companies can also be pulled by environmental factors into the exact same position. As displayed in the example above, the percentages targeted customers from each quadrant stay the same, but the hub has moved into the bottom right of the message magnet, demonstrating that it is being pulled in the direction of Quadrant A. This is what is known as a ***misaligned pull scenario***, which is due to external forces acting on a company or individual causing them to move off the center of the Brand Axis. Here, the hub of the magnet is trying to stay on center due to marketing messages that attempt to stay on brand; however, external forces are naturally pulling the company or individual message in that direction away from the centered position on the brand axis.

In this quadrant, these external forces can be the same environmental forces that are making consumers unaware that the brand exists, and even though the company may not internally decide to change its messaging to address this environmental uncertainty to acquire new customers, there in some cases may be no way to avoid it. This is not atypical for regulatory and technological changes in the environment. When major laws are passed, like the Patriot Act,

some industries are pulled into a particular stance with their messaging. While they may not want to address or discuss these issues within their marketing space, in order to gain new customers, they may have no choice but to address these new policy issues, which could naturally pull them off the center of the Brand Axis. While this external scenario may not be as prevalent as the internal one in this quadrant, it can happen in certain industries.

The Impacts

As highlighted in the percentage numbers in the graphics above, the impact of this quadrant becomes overly focused on new customers. While a company either intentionally (internal push misalignment) or unintentionally (external pull misalignment) moves into this quadrant due to environmental uncertainty, loyal customers are slipping out the back door. This misalignment creates major inefficiencies due to the decreased impact of returning customers. As demonstrated above, only 16% of the marketing message is now being organically directed at returning customers, which is a decrease of 34%. Hypothetically speaking, if a company or individual were to lose 34% of the existing or returning revenue, there most likely would be an immense amount of revenue loss. However, this scenario occurs every day as firms become overly aggressive to move into new markets. It can sometimes occur even when they are trying to stay balanced, but are pulled into this quadrant due to changing environmental conditions.

Quadrant B: Retention Focus within Environmental Uncertainty

The second quadrant of the Brand Axis includes consumers who have typically forgotten about the company's (or individual's) brand due to environmental distractions. As discussed in the previous chapters, consumers positioned closest to the X-axis are conceptually less distracted by uncertain environmental conditions, while those further away from the same axis are more distracted by uncertain environmental conditions. Likewise, consumers further away from Y-axis are perceived to be forgetting that the brand exists. Those on the far right have completely forgotten, while those closest to the Y-axis are for the most part aware of the brand, except for forgetting the smallest of minor details.

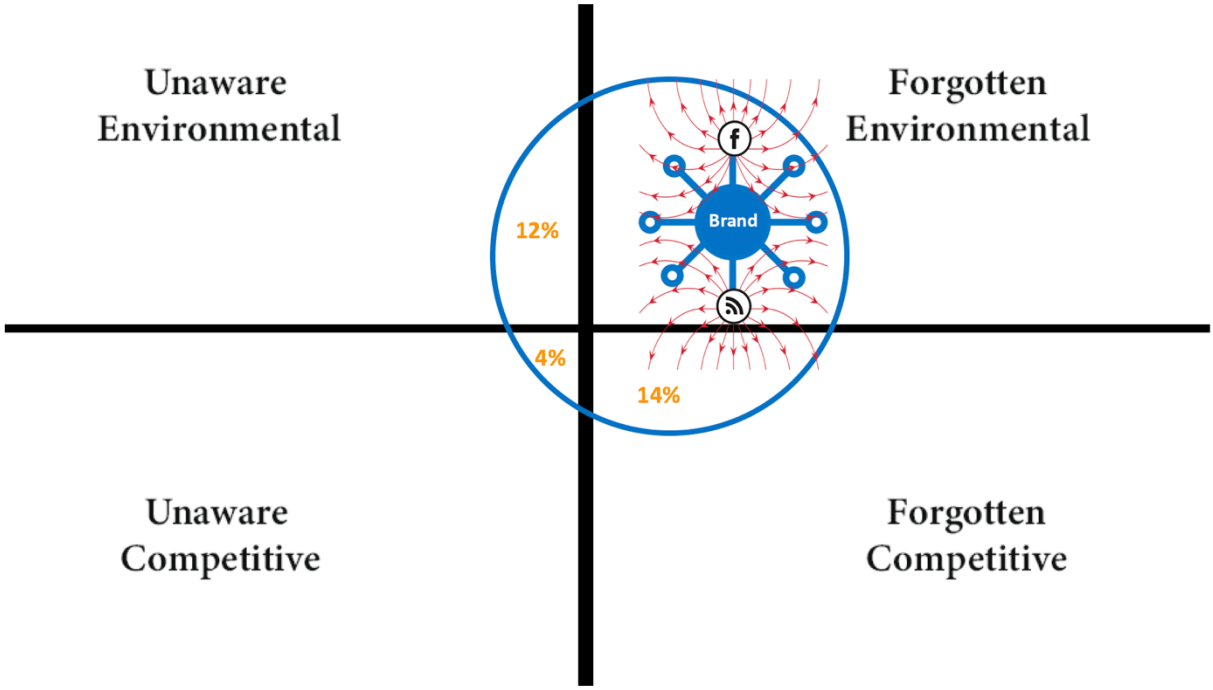
The Situation

When companies (or individuals) begin to target consumers in this quadrant, then they have become magnetically misaligned as a retention strategy in order to focus more heavily on

retaining loyal customers that have frequently purchased their product or service previously but are beginning to forget about the product or service. However, in this particular quadrant, these consumers are not being distracted by competitive offerings, but are uncertain of the product due to environmental constraints. As previously discussed, these environmental constraints can include socio-economic, political/regulatory, cultural, or technological forces that are prohibit a consumer from repurchasing. Whether the reason includes a reduction in income, cultural relevance, technological know-how, or the recent inability to access to the product or service, consumers in this quadrant are moving away from the purchase of this brand, even though they may have purchased in the past. This extinction of the brand in the mind of the consumer has made them no longer a target audience of the balanced message magnet, but into space beyond the magnet's border.

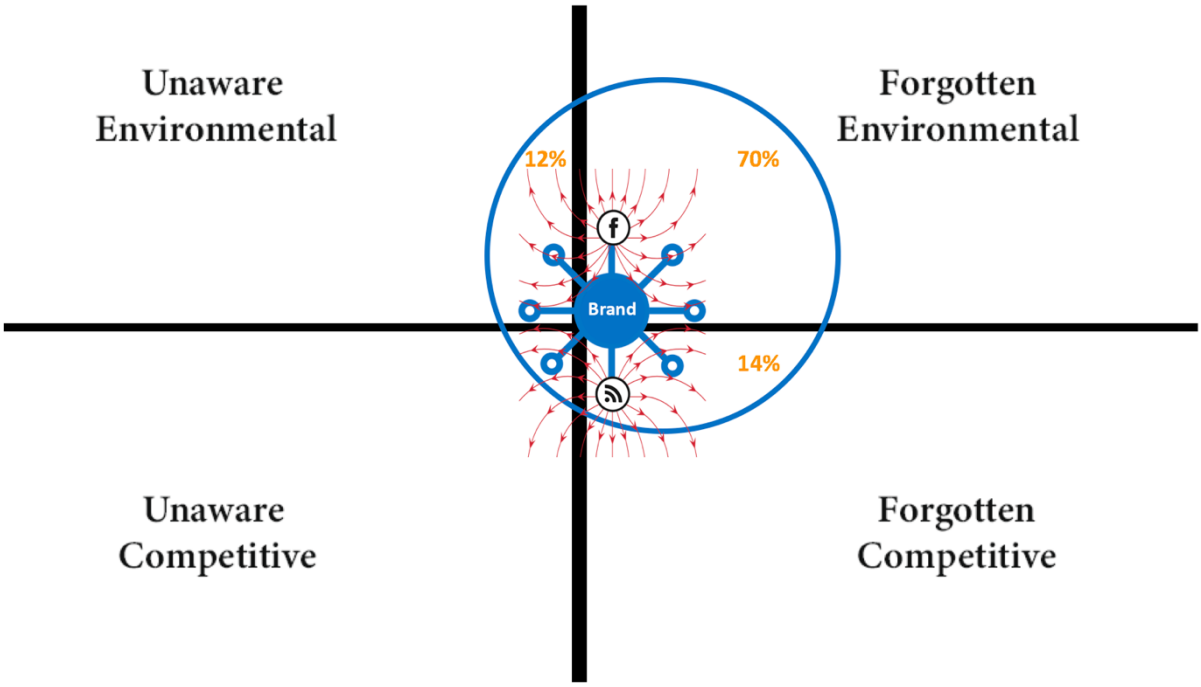
When conducting a situational analysis, companies (or individuals) may become aware of their previous consumers' movement away from the brand and become overly focused on retaining these customers at the expense of their entire branding message. Again, this misaligned push scenario is the result of an internal decision to recapture these consumers while reducing the balanced attention on acquiring new customers at the same time. In this quadrant, the message magnet becomes unbalanced, causing the company to move 70% of its messaging focus into this quadrant and away from the other three quadrants. For example, as shown in the example below, the internal decisions of this firm have pushed the message magnet off center. In this case, the other quadrants have decreasing to 14%, 4%, and 12% respectively across the other quadrants. This means that this misaligned push approach in Quadrant B has increased from a balanced 25% to an unbalanced level of 70% of the marketing message.

Figure 8. Quadrant B Push Scenario



As discussed in the previous section, the same is true for Quadrant B; that is, a firm can be "pulled" into magnetic misalignment as well. In this quadrant, it again is the same environmental forces that are making consumers forget that the brand exists, and even though the company may not internally decide to change its messaging to address this environmental uncertainty to acquire new customers, there in some cases, again, may be no way to avoid it. Just like in Quadrant A, this is not atypical for regulatory and technological changes in the environment. For example, when 5G becomes the cellular network norm, there will be some companies who may get stymied in their marketing messaged due to this technological advancement. Customers may switch brands due to use innovativeness and how they utilize apps on their devices. In this quadrant, some industries may be pulled into a particular stance with their messaging. While they may not want to address or discuss these issues within their marketing space, in order to retain customers, they may have no choice but to address these new technological advances, even to the extent of not focusing on the balance of new customers, which could naturally pull them off the center of the Brand Axis, as indicated in the figure below.

Figure 9. Quadrant B Pull Scenario



The Impacts

As highlighted in the percentage numbers in the graphics above, the impact of this quadrant becomes overly focused on previous customers. While a company either intentionally (internal push misalignment) or unintentionally (external pull misalignment) moves into this quadrant due to environmental uncertainty, opportunities in appealing to new customers are being missed. This misalignment creates additional inefficiencies due to the decreased impact of new customers. As demonstrated in the percentages above, only 16% of the marketing message is now being organically directed at new customers, which is a decrease of 34%. Hypothetically speaking, if a company or individual were to lose 34% of potential new revenue, there most likely would be an immense amount of revenue loss because the same return is unlikely in retaining the old customers who are moving on from the brand due to environmental disruptions. However, this scenario occurs every day as firms become overly aggressive to retain old customers that are moving away from the brand. It can even occur when they are trying to stay balanced, but are pulled into this quadrant due to changing environmental conditions.

Quadrant C: Retention Focus within Competitive Intensity

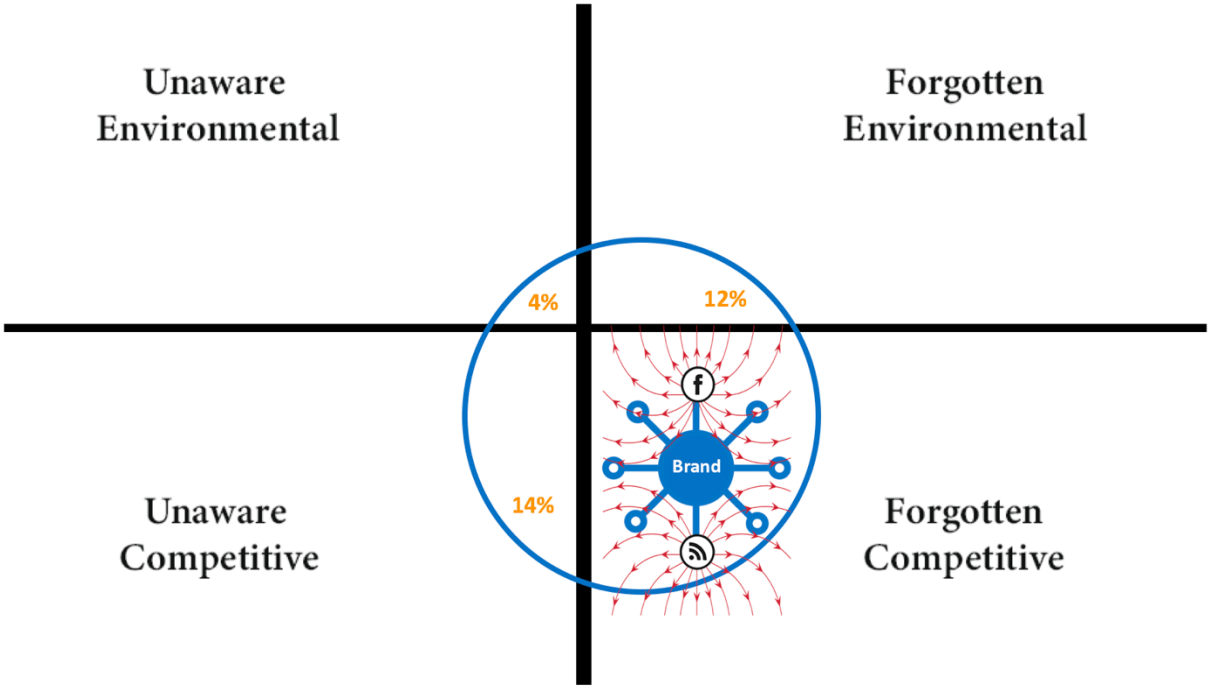
The third quadrant of the Brand Axis includes consumers who have typically forgotten about the company's (or individual's) brand due to competitive intensity. As discussed in the previous chapters, consumers positioned closest to the X-axis are conceptually less distracted by competitive messages, while those further away from the same axis are more distracted by competitors. Likewise, consumers further away from Y-axis are perceived to be forgetting that the brand exists. Those on the far right have completely forgotten, while those closest to the Y-axis are for the most part aware of the brand, except for forgetting the smallest of minor details.

The Situation

When companies (or individuals) begin to target consumers in this quadrant, then they have become magnetically misaligned as a retention strategy in order to focus more heavily on retaining loyal customers. These consumers have purchased their product or service previously, but are beginning to forget about the brand due to other attractive, more competitive options. These competitors, for many possible different reasons, are gaining the appeal of the target consumers away from their previous brand. In most instances, the value equation of the company's (or individual's) brand has been diminished due to a decrease in perception of one or more of the four P's: Product, Place, Price, or Promotion. [Note: A decrease in the perception of price is actually a price increase.] This forgetting of the brand in the mind of the consumer has moved them outside the borders of a balanced message magnet, as the consumer is no longer part of the company's (or individual's) target market.

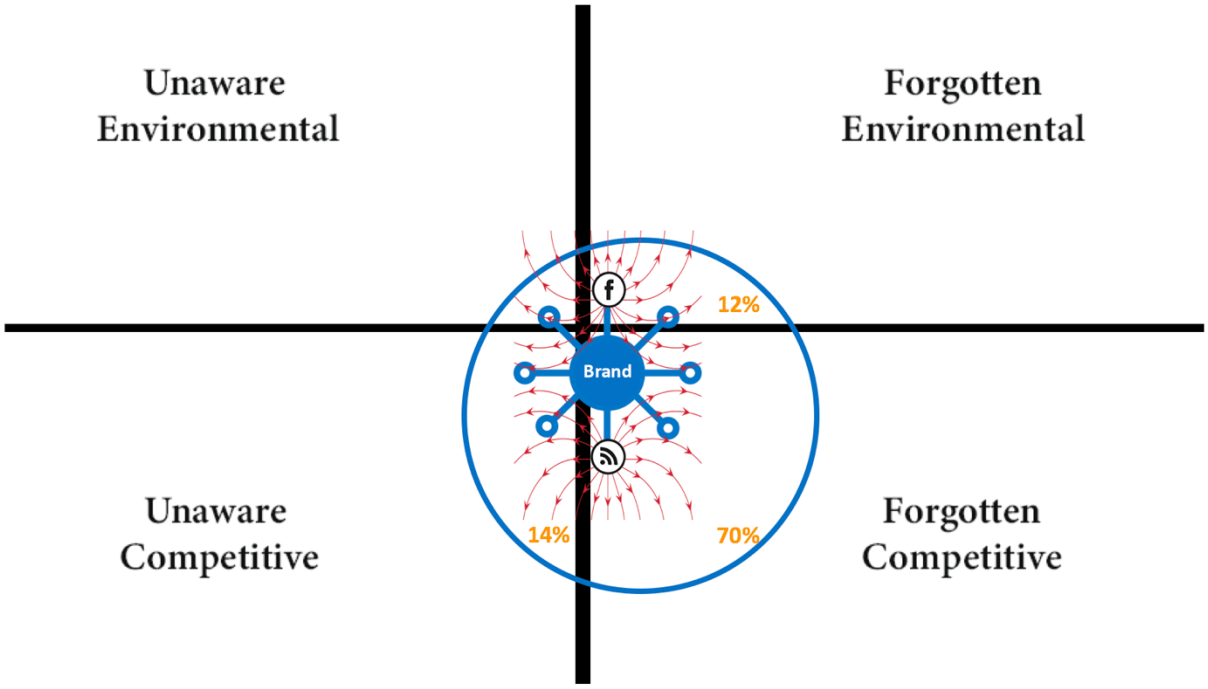
When conducting a situational analysis, companies (or individuals) may become aware of their previous consumers' movement away from the brand and become overly focused on retaining these customers at the expense of their entire branding message. Again, this misaligned push scenario is the result of an internal decision to recapture these consumers while reducing the balanced attention on acquiring new customers at the same time. As highlighted in the example below, the message magnet becomes unbalanced, causing the company to move 70% of its messaging focus into this quadrant and away from the other three quadrants. As shown, the internal decisions of this firm have pushed the message magnet off center. In this case, the other quadrants have decreasing to 14%, 4%, and 12% respectively across the other quadrants. This means that this misaligned push approach in Quadrant C has increased from a balanced 25% to an unbalanced level of 70% of the marketing message.

Figure 10. Quadrant C Push Scenario



As discussed in previous sections, Quadrant C is similar in that a firm can be "pulled" into magnetic misalignment as well. In this quadrant, the same competitive forces that are making consumers forget that the brand exists, are causing the brand to become misaligned. Even though the company may not internally decide to change its messaging to address these exact competitors' attempt to steal market share, competitive advertising may thrust the company (or individual) into the heat of the battle. In fact, for this very reason, some countries do not allow competitive advertising. Like in South Africa, the practice is considered illegal, although in the United States, we see it all of the time (e.g. Ford vs. Chevy Trucks). In this example, some companies (or individuals) can be pulled into misalignment by the actions of competing firms, which could naturally pull them off the center of the Brand Axis, as indicated in the figure below.

Figure 11. Quadrant C Pull Scenario



The Impacts

As highlighted in the percentage numbers in the graphics above, the impact of this quadrant becomes overly focused on retaining previous customers at the expense of acquiring new ones. While a company either intentionally (internal push misalignment) or unintentionally (external pull misalignment) moves into this quadrant due to competitive intensity, opportunities in appealing to new customers are being overlooked. As in Quadrant B, this misalignment creates inefficiencies due to the decreased impact of new customers. As demonstrated from the percentages above, only 16% of the marketing message is now being organically directed at new customers, which is a decrease of 34%. Hypothetically speaking, if a company or individual were to lose 34% of potential new revenue, there most likely would be an immense amount of profit loss because the same return is unlikely in retaining the old customers who are moving on from the brand due to competitive intensity. As with all of the other quadrants, the misalignment creates unequaled opportunity, resulting in fewer sales and lost profit. Although, this scenario occurs every day as firms become overly aggressive to retain old customers that are moving away from the brand. It occurs even when they are trying to stay balanced, but are pulled into this quadrant due to competition.

Quadrant D: Acquisition Focus within Competitive Intensity

The fourth and final quadrant consumers who are typically unaware of the company's (or individual's) brand due to due to competitive intensity. As discussed in the previous chapters, consumers positioned closest to the X-axis are conceptually less distracted by competitive messages, while those further away from the same axis are more distracted by competitors. Likewise, consumers further away from Y-axis are perceived to be forgetting that the brand exists. Likewise, consumers closest to the Y-axis are conceptually more aware that the brand exists than those further away from the same axis.

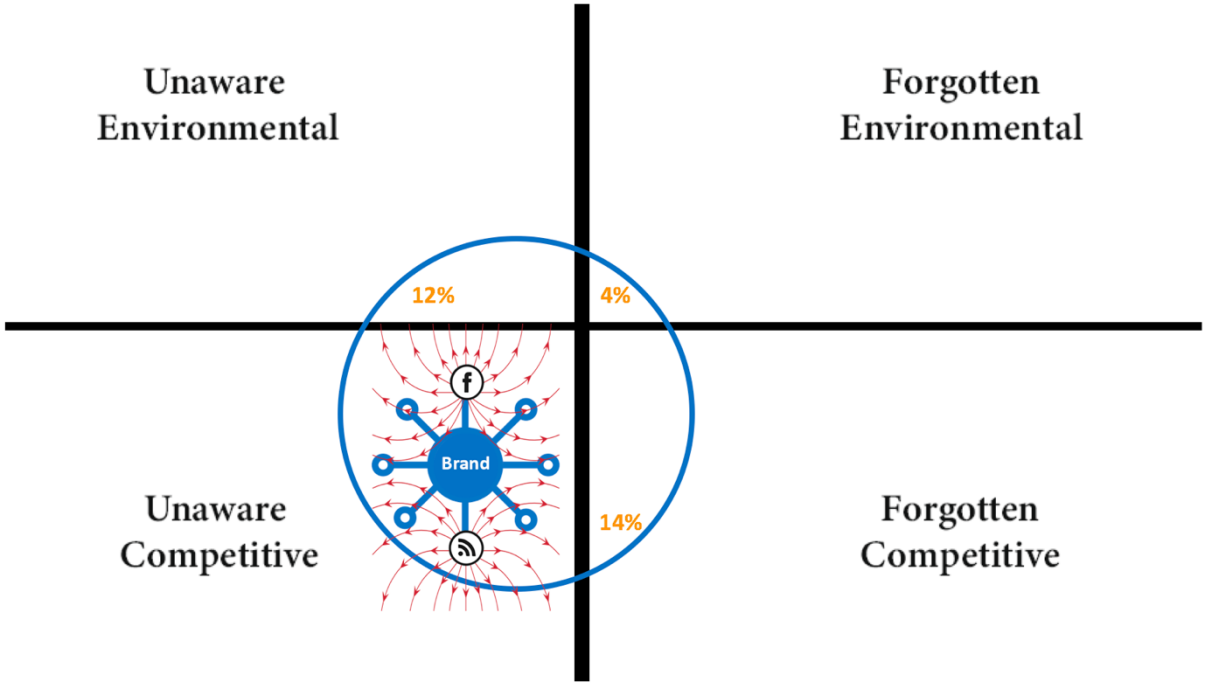
The Situation

When companies (or individuals) begin to target consumers in this quadrant, then they have become magnetically misaligned as an acquisition strategy in order to focus more heavily on establishing new customers. These consumers have never, or very rarely, purchased the brand previously due to having already been persuaded to other competing brands. These competitors, for many possible different reasons, have already gained the appeal of the target consumers before the customer might even consider the company's (or individual's) brand. In most instances, the value equation of the competing brand has already convinced consumers towards their brand due to a competitive advantage across one or more of the four P's: Product, Place, Price, or Promotion. The unawareness of the company's (or individual's) brand in the mind of the consumer has prevented him or her from entering into the borders of a balanced message magnet, as the consumer has never previously become part of the company's (or individual's) target market.

When conducting a situational analysis, companies (or individuals) may become aware and too focused on accessing these consumers at the expense of their entire branding message. Again, this misaligned push scenario is the result of an internal decision to capture these consumers while reducing the balanced attention on retaining new customers at the same time. As demonstrated in the example below, the message magnet becomes unbalanced, causing the company to move 70% of its messaging focus into this quadrant and away from the other three quadrants. As demonstrate, the internal decisions of this firm have pushed the message magnet off-center. In this case, the other quadrants have decreasing to 12%, 4%, and 14% respectively

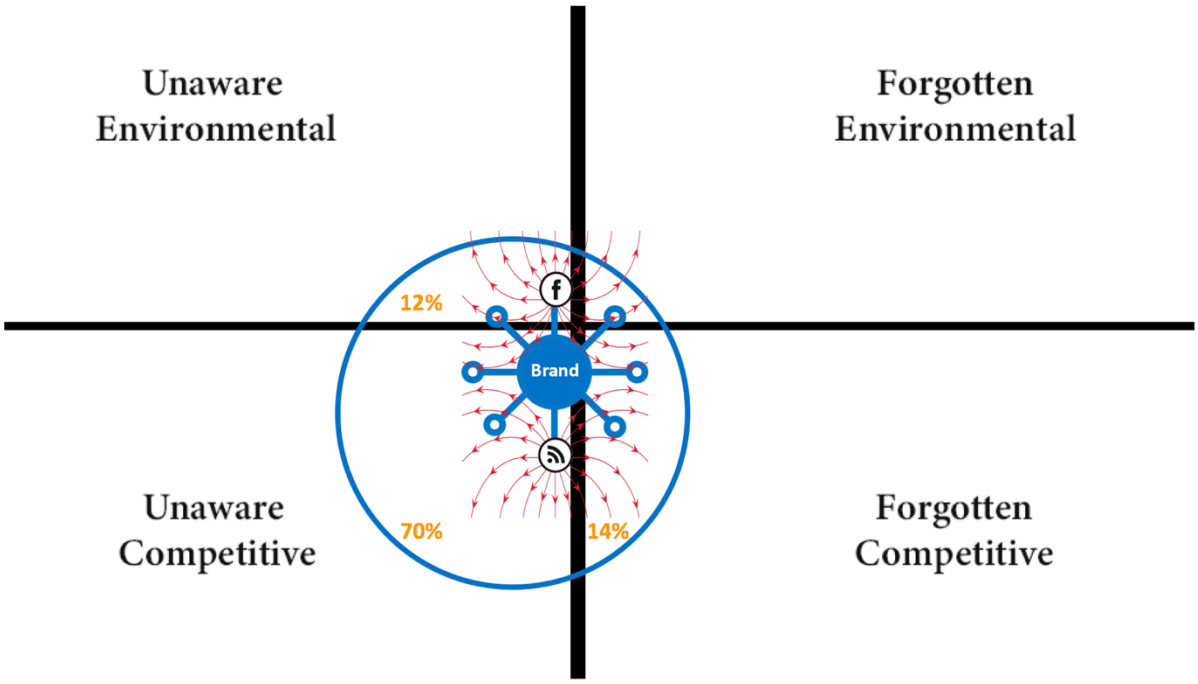
across the other quadrants. This means that this misaligned push approach in Quadrant D has increased from a balanced 25% to an unbalanced level of 70% of the marketing message.

Figure 12. Quadrant D Push Scenario



As discussed in previous sections, Quadrant D is similar in that a firm can experience a misaligned pull scenario as well. In this quadrant, the same competitive forces that are making consumers unaware that the company's (or individual's) brand exists, are causing the brand to become misaligned. Even though the company may not internally decide to change its messaging to address these exact competitors' attempt to allow any consideration of another brand, the saturation of a competitor's message within the overall market may demand that the company (or individual) address their own competitive disadvantages in the marketplace. In this example, the company (or individual) can be pulled into misalignment by the mere marketing actions of competing firms, which would force them to move towards consumers that may have never heard of their brand, or at least, very little about the brand. In this example, the shear lack of market share due to the competitive dominance of other brand can move the message magnet off-center of the Brand Axis, as indicated in the figure below.

Figure 13. Quadrant D Pull Scenario



The Impacts

As highlighted in the percentage numbers in the graphics above, the impact of this quadrant becomes overly focused on acquiring new customers at the expense of retaining previous ones. While a company either intentionally (internal push misalignment) or unintentionally (external pull misalignment) moves into this quadrant due to competitive intensity, opportunities in keeping prior customers are being overlooked. Just like in Quadrant A, this misalignment creates inefficiencies due to the decreased impact of previous customers. As demonstrated from the percentages above, only 16% of the marketing message is now being organically directed at loyal customers, which is a decrease of 34%. Hypothetically speaking, if a company or individual were to lose 34% of potential new revenue, there most likely would be an immense amount of profit loss because the same return is unlikely in acquiring new customers who have never heard of the brand due to competitive intensity. As with all of the other quadrants, the misalignment creates unequaled opportunity, resulting in fewer sales and lost profit. Although, this scenario occurs every day as firms become overly aggressive to acquire new customers at the expense of their competitors, they are just being pulled into this quadrant due to competition intensity.

The Remedy to Magnetic Misalignment

Whether it is a misaligned push or pull scenario, companies (or individuals) that find themselves in any of these quadrants need to return to their four brand elements with a strategic intent to stay balanced between new and returning customers. When considering the four brand elements, companies (or individuals) need to consider each of the following: the brand story, their brand promises, their brand beliefs, and brand trust. In order to bring the message magnet back into alignment, then the brand must return to their original story to refocus the brand messages.

Much like a mission statement, the brand story requires that every other brand decision and brand message must build upon the story. In any future decision, if the outcome is in opposition to the brand story, then one should decide against it. The story is about the personal journey that the company or individual has taken in creating the brand. It can be about how the company (or individual) came up with the idea, product, or service. Or it could be metaphoric, and while it may not be an actual story, it would be a realistic narrative around the concept or idea. The story answers questions about the emotion, authenticity, and its historical nature of the brand. It helps identify who would want or need the brand and how it fulfills those desires. The story lays the foundation for the brand promises that the individual or company will always uphold.

If the brand story is a mission statement, then the brand promise is the vision statement. What are those things that a company will promise to do for their customers and how do they intend to keep this promise? Brand promises give way to brand beliefs, which are the pillars of value that a company not only believes about the brand, but attempt to convince their consumers to believe about the brand. These values are built upon the foundation of the brand story and the brand promises, all combining together to invoke brand trust. Brand trust is that personal relationship that is built over time as satisfaction by both parties, brand and consumer alike, is accomplished and repeated time and time again.

The reality is that when brands become misaligned, they more often push themselves into a magnetic misalignment than are pushed by the landscape conditions around them. It is in fact most often a misfortune of their own strategic misguided ways. They lose sight of the key brand elements. They become distracted and lose a grip on who they are and who their customers are, what they want, and how the company can provide it to them. Yes, undoubtedly, the pull scenarios do occur, but in all of these instances, as demonstrated by each quadrant's example, the

hub is already naturally closer to the center of the Brand Axis. In these situations, the return to center is much easier as the company (or individual) has remained as centered as possible in the environmental and competitive pulls. It is much faster and more likely that these companies will return to center as soon as the landscape condition is alleviated, but for those misaligned push scenarios, those companies (or individuals) are voluntarily going deep into the quadrant as the result of internal strategic decisions. The road to recovery is long and arduous as the center of the Brand Axis is almost at times unrecognizable, not only to the company but their target customers as well.

CONCLUSION

A company will never stay centered on the Brand Axis indefinitely. There will always be decision opportunities that can and will move any company (or individual) off-center, off-brand into a misaligned state. But the best way to prevent it as much as possible is to continually return to the brand elements. Return to the process that established the inspiration for the brand in the first place. If the company will keep the brand elements continually front and center, then it our belief that not only will the company stay centered in their brand messaging efforts, but over time the company will start to see their message magnet grow and expand equally and dimensionally into all four quadrants of the Brand Axis. Returning to an earlier example, we would point out a brand like Coca-Cola. While it's tagline may have changed over the years[1] from "Have a Coke and a Smile" (1979), "Red, White, and You" (1986), "Life Taste's Good" (2001), or "Open Happiness" (2009), the brand story is focused on sharing and togetherness (Mainwaring 2014). It has always united people of all races, ages, economics, and tastes. As mentioned previously, this consistent message since 1886 has grown the message magnet on Coke's Brand Axis to virtually cover the entire infinity loop, consistently holding the brand story as the focus of its message. If a company wants their brand to become an icon, they will need to follow suit, and The Social Media Magnet pedagogy will teach students how to maintain the loyalty and engagement balance to help their company brands grow while staying centered on a balanced message of acquisition and retention.

Since the advent of Web 2.0, the marketing landscape has drastically changed. And even though practitioners have been working through these digital marketing methods for over a decade, academic pedagogies in teaching these methods are in their infancy. Many academics are fearful to jump in with both feet because to teach these methods, he or she seemingly has to be immersed in the digital market daily to understand the connections and changes in the

marketplace. Therefore, many universities hire adjuncts to teach the digital marketing curriculum. While this is a legitimate strategy, the problem is that many adjuncts do not deliver in the classroom the way that professionally trained academics deliver, and additionally, they only deliver the exact methodology of what they have been trained to do in the field. Most of the time, these adjuncts are from agencies; therefore, much of the digital class is spend on paid digital media. As these authors have already contended earlier in this article, the class becomes more focused on pay-per-clicks and not content creation and/or curation. The problem here is that before one should boost a post or pay for a Facebook advertisement, he or she should know how that post or ad would run in the organic space first. If the post was successful in the organic space, then it sure to be successful in the paid space. This sort of A/B testing is needed on the organic side of content creation before introduced into the paid arena. But again, our university systems just do not have many professors who have had the time or the willingness to learn the inbound marketing approaches. This is where The Social Media Magnet can hopefully start to change these behaviors.

The Social Media Magnet pedagogy has been created as a lifeline to connect professors to the tools, resources, assignments, and practicum needed to teach the organic, inbound strategies and tactics for today's college students. The hope is that it will provide students with the foundation on how to create brand strategies using digital content, implement those content strategies, and monitor/audit with the current marketing analytics provided to us through and alongside these current digital platforms. Most importantly, not only will students learn these tools, but have created their own assets to use as a resume highlight. At the end of the semester, they will have a fully functional campaign of their own to use as proof of these highly valued skillsets. They will have not only the working understanding, but they will be able to speak the language with both company and agency alike, those who are looking to employ the graduates with these specific skills.

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